

Session 21: Reflecting on God's Covenant

Key Takeaways

- Unlike the gods of Israel's neighbors who made promises contingent upon the people upholding the terms of their covenant, God obligates himself alone to sustain the covenant he made with all the Earth after the flood.
- The sign of the bow evokes images of peace (the retired war bow), reconciliation (a bridge between Heaven and Earth), and hope (the triumph of light over the darkness of the chaotic storm).

The Image of the "Bow in the Clouds" (Gen. 9:13, 14, 16)

"And is there not to every law of nature a background pointing to the mysteries of the Divine nature and will? The label of the rainbow is sufficiently legible. Shining upon a dark ground ... it represents the victory of the light of love over the fiery darkness of wrath. Originating from the effect of the sun upon a dark cloud, it typifies the willingness of the heavenly to penetrate the earthly. Stretched between heaven and earth, it is as a bond of peace between both, and, spanning the horizon, it points to the all-embracing universality of the Divine mercy."

Keil, C. F., and Delitzsch, F. (2006). [*Commentary on the Old Testament: Pentateuch \(Vol. 1\)*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 289-290.

Noah as an Archetypal Seed of the Woman

"While God is the main character of the narrative, Noah the righteous priest may yet be considered the literary 'hero' of the story, who both 'walks with' and 'brings rest' to God. Noah (נח), in fact, brings 'comfort' (נחם) both to humankind and to God. But further, not only because the narrative begins and ends with God's speech to Noah; and not only because the various wordplays on his name indicate Noah as a central character; but because the central question of the narrative concern salvation and worship: 'Who may ascend the mountain of Yahweh?' (Psalm 24:3) The flood narrative is really about Noah. This is to stress that the narrative is not really about the judgment of the world, but about how it was that Noah was saved from that judgment. ... The purpose of the story is not to show why God sent the flood, but to show why God saved Noah. The ark, not the flood, is the focus of the author's attention. ... As a priestly figure who is able to ascend the mountain of Yahweh, Noah stands as a new Adam, the primordial human who can dwell in the divine presence. As such he foreshadows the high priest in the tabernacle, who alone can enter the paradise of the holy of holies to purge the micro-cosmic tabernacle by making atonement."

Morales, Michael (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers. 190-192.



This session has no other notes

Reflection Question

Have you ever considered the horizontal, half-circle shape of a rainbow? It almost looks like a bow for shooting arrows. What does God's bow in the clouds represent?